

CHANGING

1776–1914

From the late 18th century, history took on a perhaps delusory air of “progress.” Change accelerated and seemed to have a clear direction. The world population exceeded 1 billion in 1804 and was approaching 2 billion by 1914. This growth was made possible by tremendous increases in economic output. Agriculture became more efficient and large areas of new land were put to productive use. The exploitation of new sources of energy—especially steam power—the application of new technology, and organized industrial production in factories revolutionized the manufacture of commodities. Railroads made it possible for humans to travel faster than a horse for the first time and cities expanded—for instance, the population in London increased from 1 million in 1800 to 7 million in 1910. Improvements in public health and medicine increased life expectancy in the most advanced countries.

Human rights and equality

Despite these advancements, it is debatable whether progress was detectable in the quality of life. At the start of this period, political revolutions in America and France enunciated principles of human

rights and equal citizenship that radically challenged the existing order of society. By the early 20th century, liberals and democrats in Europe and North America could look with some complacency upon successes such as the widespread expansion of voting rights, the abolition of slavery, and freedom of speech. However, women remained mostly excluded from voting, and there was no economic equality. Extremes of wealth and poverty polarized the world’s wealthiest and most advanced societies, and conditions of life for industrial workers were often very miserable. Artists and intellectuals of the Romantic movement criticized the impact of mechanized industry on people and the environment, while socialist movements looked forward to further revolutions that would end the exploitation of man by man and create egalitarian societies.

Western imperialism

The most obvious losers in the new world order created by industrial capitalism were the inhabitants of countries at the periphery of the global economy. The industrializing countries of the West, needing places to invest their excess